

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a newspaper in Hong Kong:

Too many signals?

The Hong Kong Observatory was founded in 1883. Back then, it had a number of roles but the most important was providing accurate weather observations and a typhoon warning service. For shipping, which played a central role in the city's development, these warnings were vital.

In the more than a century since its establishment, the agency has evolved due to the changing expectations in the city and so has the number of weather warnings. There are now 21 weather warning signals. During the summer months it is common for warnings to be issued every day of the month and sometimes multiple warnings are issued at the same time.

However, referring to the number of signals now used, Marco Wong Tse-yan, a senior manager for a local fast-food chain, said: "The signals are confusing and not appropriate for modern international businesses; many shops don't even close now for some typhoon signal number eights because the weather might not be too bad." As Hong Kong has become more developed, the effect of the weather on daily life has reduced and not only are businesses questioning the use of signals but some schools also feel they are closing unnecessarily.

An Observatory spokeswoman, answering complaints about the effect warnings have on economic activities, said they make decisions purely on the basis of scientific data, rather than taking into account the impact a No.8 signal would have on businesses.

You are doing a project about the Hong Kong Observatory and you have been asked to discuss how suitable the current signals in Hong Kong are. You may want to talk about:

- the advantages of the current warning signals
- possible problems caused for families, schools and businesses by the current signals
- possible improvements to the current system
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. How do you feel when a typhoon is coming to Hong Kong?
2. What do you do when there is no school because of a bad weather warning?
3. What do most people do during typhoons?
4. How do you feel when the red rain signal is raised?
5. What companies suffer the most from typhoons in modern day Hong Kong?
6. Have you ever been frightened in a typhoon?
7. What should the police do about people going to the beach during Typhoon Number 8?
8. Do you think it is fair for taxis to charge double the fare during a typhoon?